THE PRICE OF DAWN — D100 TWILIGHT CHARACTER GROUNDING TABLE

Varenhold Atmosphere & Ties · Roll 1d100 for sensory anchors, moral weight & campaign memories

I. LIGHT, TWILIGHT & THE SKY (01–10)

01. **[THE SUN]** Do you personally remember the real sun before the Twilight, or has daylight only ever been a myth and memory told by elders?

02. **[THE SKY]** When you look up at Varenhold's perpetual slate-grey overcast, do you find the unchanging ceiling suffocating, or strangely comforting?

03. **[AMBER GLOW]** The city runs on warm amber streetlamps and lanterns. Do you prefer lingering in the warm pools of lamplight, or moving unseen in the shadows?

04. **[FIRST SHADOW]** Under amber light, shadows are sharp and amber-edged. What is your earliest memory of being startled or fascinated by your own shadow?

05. **[COLORS]** Without true sunlight, colors in Varenhold are muted greys, browns, and ambers. What rare, vivid color are you always drawn to when you spot it?

06. **[THE LAMP]** What kind of light source do you personally rely on when travelling through the city: a brass amber lantern, a smoky tallow torch, or magical light?

07. **[BLIND SPOT]** Have you ever stared too long into an amber furnace or flare until your eyes hurt? What did you think you saw dancing in the heat?

08. **[NIGHTFALL]** In a city where it is always dusk, how does your body know when it is time to sleep when bells fail to ring?

09. **[PRE-DAWN LORE]** What is the most poetic or absurd thing you have heard an elder claim the sun was capable of doing before the sky died?

10. **[A GLIMPSE]** If you could see the sun break through the clouds for just sixty seconds, where in the city would you want to be standing to witness it?

II. THE COLD, HEARTH & WARMTH (11–20)

11. **[THE CHILL]** Where does the damp cold of Varenhold settle into your body first: your fingers, your boots, your chest, or an old ache in your bones?

12. **[LAYERS]** Describe the layers of clothing, cloaks, furs, or wraps your character bundles into daily just to keep the biting frost at bay.

13. **[COMFORT FOOD]** When you are freezing and exhausted, what hot meal or brew restores your spirit: chicory tea, thick mushroom pottage, or spiced tallow bread?

14. **[THE HEARTH]** Do you sleep better beside a crackling hearthfire with light flickering on the walls, or bundled alone in pitch darkness?

15. **[FROZEN WATER]** Have you ever slipped or broken through the crust of a frozen canal? What lesson about Varenhold's winter did that close call teach you?

16. **[WARMTH OF OTHERS]** Are you someone who readily shares your fire and blankets with shivering strangers, or do you guard your warmth jealously?

17. **[BREATH]** Everyone's breath plumed white in the air. When you speak to someone in the cold, do you watch their eyes, or watch their pluming breath?

18. **[FINGERS]** Your hands must be nimble for your craft, weapon, or spells. How do you keep your fingers warm enough to act when danger strikes?

19. **[THE DEEP FREEZE]** What was the harshest, most desperate winter night you ever endured, and how did you survive until the morning bells?

20. **[SUMMER MEMORY]** If you ever experienced genuine warmth—natural summer heat, hot spring water, or magic—how did it feel compared to furnace heat?

III. DAILY LIFE & THE SENSES OF VARENHOLD (21–30)

21. **[MORNING SOUND]** What distinctive sound tells you a new day has begun: cathedral tolling bells, iron coal carts on cobblestones, or street hawkers?

22. **[CITY SMELL]** Varenhold smells of coal soot, river mud, burning amber, and wet wool. Which of these scents do you notice most when stepping outside?

23. **[FLICKERING OMEN]** When an amber streetlamp suddenly flickers and gutters in an alleyway, what is your instinctive reaction: draw steel, or make a quiet prayer?

24. **[FOOTWEAR]** What state are your boots in? Are they sturdy waxed leather, patched up with rags, or reinforced with iron studs for grip on icy stones?

25. **[TIMEKEEPING]** How do you keep track of hours and appointments: church bells, a pocket watch, a candle with hourly pins, or pure internal rhythm?

26. **[RIVER FOG]** When the heavy, sulfurous fog rolls off the Graymere river, does the blindness make you feel vulnerable, or do you welcome the cover?

27. **[STREET HABITS]** Do you walk with your eyes locked forward and hood low to avoid attention, or do you scan rooftops and alley mouths as you walk?

28. **[TAVERN HAVEN]** When you have a spare copper mark and an hour of peace, what kind of tavern do you seek: a boisterous taproom or a quiet corner booth?

29. **[PERSONAL TOKEN]** What small, seemingly worthless object do you carry in your pocket that you habitually touch when anxious or deep in thought?

30. **[THE SILENCE]** Late at night when street noise dies down, the silence under the twilight can be oppressive. How do you quiet your mind before sleeping?

IV. FOOD, SCARCITY & THE AMBER ECONOMY (31–40)

31. **[THE RATION]** Fresh fruit and vegetables are legendary luxuries in Varenhold. What common, preserved ration are you utterly sick of eating?

32. **[AMBER WRITS]** The Compact taxes and strictly controls amber heating fuel. How do you feel about the merchants and wardens who hoard the warmth?

33. **[A RARE FEAST]** What was the most extravagant or memorable meal you ever tasted in this city, and who were you sharing it with?

34. **[BARTER]** Coin is often useless when supplies run dry. What valuable skill, favor, or item do you trade when people refuse copper marks?

35. **[HUNGER]** Have you ever experienced true, gnawing hunger during a fuel or flour shortage? How did that hunger change the way you look at food?

36. **[A LUXURY RELIC]** You come across an artifact from the sunlit era—a parasol, a straw sunhat, or a sundial. Do you find it tragic, beautiful, or laughable?

37. **[HOARDING]** Do you keep a secret emergency stash of food, coin, or fuel tucked away somewhere, or do you live strictly day-to-day?

38. **[GENEROSITY]** When you see a freezing beggar or an orphan huddled over a street vent, do you give what you have, or harden your heart to survive?

39. **[THE SMUGGLERS]** Contraband fuel and unregistered amber glass move along the canals every night. Do you view smugglers as criminals, or life-savers?

40. **[WINDFALL]** If you suddenly came into fifty gold sovereigns tomorrow, what is the very first thing you would buy for yourself or your companions?

V. THE GREY SICKNESS & MORTALITY (41–50)

41. **[THE ASH COUGH]** The Grey Sickness begins with a dry, chalky cough. Whenever you clear your throat on a cold morning, does a flash of fear cross your mind?

42. **[FIRST WITNESS]** Who was the first person you ever saw afflicted by the petrifying touch of the Grey Sickness, and how did watching them affect you?

43. **[FOLK REMEDIES]** What strange home remedy—vinegar rags, pine pitch tea, crushed birch bark—did someone once claim could ward off the ash?

44. **[THE HEALING HOUSE]** How do you view the Lowmark Healing House: a heroic sanctuary of compassionate healers, or a grim waystation where people go to die?

45. **[QUARANTINE]** If a close ally began showing subtle tremors in their fingers, would you urge them to seek quarantine healers, or help them hide it?

46. **[BURIAL RITES]** In Varenhold, the dead are often interred in deep stone crypts to escape the frost. What are your personal thoughts on what lies after death?

47. **[PHYSICAL SCARS]** What physical scar or mark on your body carries the most meaningful story, and do you show it openly or keep it covered?

48. **[STREET SUPERSTITION]** What morbid rumor or superstition about the Grey Sickness have you overheard in taprooms that you half-suspect might be true?

49. **[THE INEVITABLE]** In a world where winter never relents and sickness lingers in the fog, what keeps you fighting for tomorrow instead of giving up?

50. **[A HEALER'S DEBT]** Has a doctor, apothecary, or herbalist ever saved your life or sewn you back together? Did you pay them in full, or do you still owe them?

VI. CITY QUARTERS & LOCAL ROOTS (51–60)

51. **[HOME GROUND]** Which quarter of Varenhold feels most familiar to your boots: the crowded Lowmark, the fortified Ashring, or the canal-side docks?

52. **[DREADED DISTRICT]** Which neighborhood or district in the city gives you an uneasy chill whenever you are forced to walk its streets alone?

53. **[THE HIGH SPIRE]** When you look up at the Spire of Astronomers piercing the overcast, do you see a beacon of ancient wisdom, or a symbol of elite arrogance?

54. **[THE CANAL BRIDGES]** The stone bridges crossing the black canal waters are prime ambush spots. How do you cross a bridge when night falls?

55. **[OLD RUINS]** Varenhold is built atop centuries of older stone. Have you ever explored an old cellar, flooded crypt, or abandoned sewer beneath the streets?

56. **[THE OUTER WALLS]** Have you ever stood on the city ramparts and looked out into the vast, dark wilderness beyond? Did you feel protected, or trapped?

57. **[FAVORITE VIEW]** What is the single most striking or oddly beautiful architectural sight in the city that always catches your eye?

58. **[THE WATCH]** When you hear the synchronized boots of an armed city patrol approaching around a corner, is your instinct to stand tall, or step into a doorway?

59. **[SAFE HAVEN]** Where in Varenhold is the one spot where you can let your guard down completely and feel genuinely safe for a few hours?

60. **[THE OUTSIDE WORLD]** Were you born within Varenhold's walls, or did you travel here from the distant parishes or beyond? Do you consider this city your home?

VII. FAITH, SUPERSTITION & THE SILENT GODS (61–70)

61. **[PRIVATE PRAYER]** When you find yourself in mortal terror or desperate need, which god or power do you instinctively address in your thoughts?

62. **[AURIS THE SUN]** Cathedrals still preach devotion to Auris, the God of the Sun. Do you regard Auris with genuine devotion, anger, or hollow indifference?

63. **[SOLENNE OF THE HEARTH]** Solenne represents the hearthfire, domestic warmth, and hospitality. Do you honor the hearth goddess, and how do you show it?

64. **[FORGOTTEN DEITIES]** Do you place any faith in older, pre-city spirits—gods of the cold river, the soil, the winter moon, or ancient stone?

65. **[HOLY TOKENS]** Do you wear or carry a religious symbol, consecrated prayer strip, or warding talisman? What does it mean to you personally?

66. **[THE SILENCE OF GODS]** For fifty years, prayers for true sunrise have gone unanswered. In your opinion, did the gods turn their backs, or are they weeping with us?

67. **[SACRED RITUAL]** What small personal ritual—lighting a taper, spilling a drop of ale, touching cold iron—do you perform before facing dangerous odds?

68. **[CATHEDRAL ECHOES]** Have you ever stood beneath the towering vaulted ceilings of the Grand Cathedral? Did the grandeur inspire awe, or feel like an empty cage?

69. **[BLASPHEMY]** What doubt or irreverent thought about the divine have you harbored in your chest that you would never dare utter aloud in a temple?

70. **[A MIRACLE'S COST]** If a priest told you the gods would bring back the sun, but only in exchange for a tremendous civic sacrifice, would you believe them?

VIII. ORIGINS, MENTORS & OLD MEMORIES (71–80)

71. **[THE MENTOR]** Who taught you your most important skill—how to fight, cast, negotiate, or survive? What was the hardest lesson they drilled into you?

72. **[FAMILY LEGACY]** What trade, reputation, or burden did your family or caregivers leave behind for you in Varenhold?

73. **[CHILDHOOD GAMES]** What games or mischief did you get up to as a youth in the shadow of the lamps, and who was your partner-in-crime?

74. **[AN OLD LOSS]** Who from your earlier years do you miss the most, and what is one memory of them that still brings a faint smile to your face?

75. **[ELDERS' TALES]** What story told by an elder by the fireside stuck with you so deeply that you still find yourself thinking about it on dark nights?

76. **[A PRIZED HEIRLOOM]** What physical object that you still own has the deepest sentimental value to you, regardless of how much gold it is worth?

77. **[YOUTHFUL AMBITION]** What did you dream of becoming before the harsh realities of survival in Varenhold took hold of your life?

78. **[A PARTING WORD]** What was the last thing someone important told you before you set out on your current path in life?

79. **[FIRST WEAPON OR TOOL]** Do you remember the very first weapon, arcane focus, or tool of your trade that felt truly yours? Where did you get it?

80. **[A MOMENT OF LAUGHTER]** In a city filled with grim faces and cold fog, when was the last time you laughed until your sides hurt, and what caused it?

IX. FELLOWSHIP & COMPANION BONDS (81–90)

81. **[THE WATCHER]** Which of your party companions do you feel most comfortable sleeping near when you are on watch during the dead hours?

82. **[A SECRET RESPECTED]** You have noticed that one of your companions carries a private sorrow or secret. Do you respect their silence, or try to draw them out?

83. **[DIFFERENT MINDS]** Which companion has an outlook on life most opposite to your own, and what about their worldview do you secretly respect?

84. **[THE ANCHOR]** When chaos erupts in battle or crisis, whose voice among your allies helps you steady your nerves and focus your resolve?

85. **[A SHARED MEAL]** Which of your companions would you most trust to cook a meal from scarce rations, and which one would you never let near the pot?

86. **[IN THE TRENCHES]** Think of a recent moment where a companion saved you from injury or humiliation. How did you thank them, if at all?

87. **[WORRY]** Which of your companions do you worry about the most when things turn grim, fearing they might throw their life away for others?

88. **[MORAL COMPASS]** When a difficult, morally grey decision faces the group, whose judgment among your peers do you weigh most heavily?

89. **[UNSPOKEN BOND]** What is something you would willingly sacrifice for your companions that you would never admit aloud to them?

90. **[LIFTING SPIRITS]** When the party is shivering, exhausted, and losing hope, what is your way of trying to restore morale or ease the tension?

X. THE RUMOR OF DAWN & THE COST OF HOPE (91–100)

91. **[BELIEF IN DAWN]** In your quietest moments, do you genuinely believe a true, radiant sunrise will ever return to this world, or is twilight permanent?

92. **[THE DAWNBORN]** People born on the night the sun failed carry lingering dawn in their veins. How do you view them: blessed by light, or cursed by fate?

93. **[THE MORNING AFTER]** If the true sun blazed across the mountains tomorrow, what is the very first thing you would do with your newfound day?

94. **[A WORLD IN SUNLIGHT]** Without the daily struggle against cold and darkness, what kind of life would you seek to build for yourself in peace?

95. **[FEAR OF LIGHT]** Does the prospect of true daylight frighten you in any way? What secrets or flaws might full sunlight reveal that darkness hides?

96. **[THE FALL OF AMBER]** If daylight returns and amber fuel becomes worthless, thousands of workers and guilds will be upended. Does change excite or worry you?

97. **[THE MEASURE OF SACRIFICE]** If returning the light to Varenhold demanded a heavy, permanent sacrifice from you personally, where would you draw the line?

98. **[FREE WILL]** If a person held the power to end the twilight but refused because it would cost them their life, would you force them, or defend their choice?

99. **[WHAT REMAINS]** If the dawn is restored, what beauty or quiet kinship forged in this city of shadows will you miss when the twilight is gone?

100. **[THE PRICE OF DAWN]** They say that every dawn has an invoice written in blood, consent, and memory. In your own words, what is dawn worth to you?